“Relationships take more than they give, so they aren’t worth the effort.”

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Do you sometimes feel that relationships take more from you than they give? Do you find yourself weighing what each person costs you? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward healthier, more balanced relationships, and to find the rest that comes from knowing God’s word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

Someone who grew up caring for others, or in a home where closeness meant constant demands and little warmth, may learn that people take far more than they give. If the benefits of friendship were rarely experienced, the cost is all that is remembered.

How the belief can keep itself going

If the person invests little, relationships give little, and that seems to prove the belief. Time with draining people is counted, while unseen rewards are missed because they have never been tried. Looking at the whole picture, including what has been lost by staying away, can change the balance.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not hide the cost of love, but it tells us that giving is where blessing is found. Jesus said it is more blessed to give than to receive, and a generous person is refreshed. We are called to encourage one another and not neglect meeting together. These passages do not ignore draining relationships; they point to the fruit of well-chosen, mutual ones.

> *“And let us consider how to spur one another on to love and good deeds. Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching.” (Hebrews 10:24–25)*

Also see

> “In everything, I showed you that by this kind of hard work we must help the weak, remembering the words of the Lord Jesus Himself: ‘It is more blessed to give than to receive.’” (Acts 20:35)

> “A generous soul will prosper, and he who refreshes others will himself be refreshed.” (Proverbs 11:25)

> “This is My commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you.” (John 15:12)

> “As good stewards of the manifold grace of God, each of you should use whatever gift he has received to serve one another.” (1 Peter 4:10)

Common self-statements

- People are exhausting.
- I give and give and get nothing back.

- It is not worth the energy.
- I have better things to do than keep up friendships.
- Relationships are more work than they are worth.
- I am better off with fewer demands.

Common logical errors

- Mental filter: Focusing on the costs and overlooking the benefits.
- Overgeneralizing: Concluding that all relationships are draining because some were.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing relationships as either fully rewarding or a waste.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing good moments as exceptions.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling tired and concluding that people are not worth it.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that new relationships will cost more than they give.

Challenging questions

- What exactly do I think relationships cost, and what might they give?
- Which relationships, past or present, have been good for me?
- Have I ever invested in a relationship that was mutual and healthy?
- Is the problem relationships in general, or specific draining ones?
- What has staying away from people cost me?
- What does Scripture say about the blessing of giving and encouraging?
- How could I set limits so that relationships cost less but still give something?

Truth summary

Some relationships are draining, and I am allowed to set limits. But healthy, mutual relationships give comfort, laughter, help, and growth, and I may not have experienced much of that yet. I can choose wisely, give a little, and watch what comes back. God made relationships a source of blessing, not only of cost.

A short prayer

Lord, You know how tiring people have been for me. Heal what has been draining, and teach me healthy limits. Show me one relationship worth investing in, and let me discover the blessing You placed in it. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Friendship
- Love, For Others
- Church
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Love

- Communication
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Goodness of God
CeCe Winans

Reflect on God's goodness reaching you through others.

Known
Tauren Wells

Rest in being known and cared for.

Who You Say I Am
Hillsong Worship

Remember who you are in Christ as you choose who to invest in.

Come As You Are
Crowder

Come as you are; you need not earn your place.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call schizoid personality disorder, a long-standing pattern of detachment from close relationships and a narrow range of expressed emotion. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. A cost-benefit view of relationships can reflect real past depletion; exploring what the person has actually received, and teaching limit-setting, avoids dismissing legitimate experiences. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Similar presentations can arise from depression, trauma, social anxiety, autism spectrum differences, or temperament, so careful assessment matters. Pace any experiments to the person; someone with severe depression or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "Is there one person who gives me life, and could I spend a few minutes with them today?"

My Plan for Replacing "Relationships take more than they give, so they aren't worth the effort."

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Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "Relationships take more than they give, so they aren't worth the effort." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you think a relationship is not worth the effort.

- ☐ What exactly do I think relationships cost, and what might they give?
- ☐ Which relationships, past or present, have been good for me?
- ☐ Have I ever invested in a relationship that was mutual and healthy?
- ☐ Is the problem relationships in general, or specific draining ones?
- ☐ What has staying away from people cost me?
- ☐ What does Scripture say about the blessing of giving and encouraging?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ Some relationships drain me, and others can renew me.
- ☐ I can set limits and still stay connected.
- ☐ Giving can bring blessing back.
- ☐ I may not have tried enough healthy relationships yet.
- ☐ Good relationships give comfort, laughter, and help.
- ☐ God made us to encourage one another.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Hebrews 10:24–25
  "And let us consider how to spur one another on to love and good deeds. Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching."
- ☐ Acts 20:35
  "In everything, I showed you that by this kind of hard work we must help the weak, remembering the words of the Lord Jesus Himself: 'It is more blessed to give than to receive.'"
- ☐ Proverbs 11:25

"A generous soul will prosper, and he who refreshes others will himself be refreshed."

☐ John 15:12
"This is My commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you."

☐ 1 Peter 4:10
"As good stewards of the manifold grace of God, each of you should use whatever gift he has received to serve one another."

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

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5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Friendship. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ Make two lists about one relationship: what it costs and what it gives. Compare them honestly.
- ☐ Choose one person who has been good to you and spend a short, planned time with them.
- ☐ Do one small kind act for someone and notice how you feel afterward.
- ☐ Set one limit with a draining person, such as ending a call after twenty minutes.
- ☐ Attend one group or gathering for a short, set time, and note what you gained.
- ☐ Write a prayer thanking God for one person who has been a gift, and tell that person thank you.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about what relationships can give, and God's goodness through people.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~Relationships take more than they give, so they aren't worth the effort.~~

NEW TRUTH:
Some relationships drain me, but healthy ones give far more than they take. I can set limits and still be connected.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Hebrews 10:24–25

A short prayer

Lord, thank You for the people who have blessed me. Help me to set healthy limits, to give wisely, and to receive the good You send through others. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.